

2.11.2021 BH/SPED Subcommittee Meeting
Notes
Via Zoom

Melanie McLaughlin, Chair

Roll: 5:02 PM

Paul Ruseau, Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin All Present

Other Guests:

Carla Andre, Charlotte Heim, Joan Bowen, Stacey Schulman, Lisa Evangelista, Suzannah Campbell (parent), Clare Flaherty, Alex Lauric, Tonya Sullivan, Peter Cushing, Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Suzanne Galusi, Denise Desjardins (PT), Marissa Steinberg, Kettj Fiorentino

Charlotte Heim:

EPOCH Leaders Presentation

Came to speak at Common Ground about the EPOCH program and about Disability Civil Rights, Ableism, Person First Language

Common Ground: Reverse inclusion class at MHS

Carla Andre

It has been successful. Doing team building activities. Getting to the idea of being an elective. Currently open to CCSR kids. We want to reach beyond CCSR to include more students.

Suzannah Campbell: Disability Awareness course (5th of 5 sessions wrapped up today). Breakout rooms to build lesson plans encompassing disability awareness). Thinking about next steps after successfully building foundational knowledge.

Denise Desjardins: Spoke about Special Olympics. Malden has been hosting this in recent years. I reached out to CCSR mentor at the McGlynn and Andrews, Meghan Olson and she is very interested in getting students involved.

Melanie: infusion of disability awareness into teaching materials. Idea with Common Ground. Perhaps some buy in from the Middle School.

Open it up to discussion: 5:25PM

Carla Andre: We need to narrow it down to events within each building. I would love to talk to people at the Middle School about Common Ground.

Melanie: Universal Design for Learning. I love your utilizing the course to be used in different classrooms.

April SEPAC has a presentation on differentiated curriculum using UDL.

Joan Bowen; I want to talk about Common Ground possibly becoming an elective course. We are meeting with Paul D'Alleva after vacation about how this can happen and what the syllabus should look like.

Suzannah Campbell: Looking at the lesson plans our teachers have come up with is a great place to start. I have created a website to share the lesson plans as well as additional resources.

Melanie: Can you send us the website to share? Thanks Alex and Tonya from Sepac for moving this forward

Denise DesJardins: I highly recommend that this course be offered to all teachers. I can't speak highly enough about how important this is to our district. Wish it could be part of a pd day.

Kettj Fiorentino: I was amazed with Melanie's presentation. Building this background knowledge was so helpful. So much I didn't know but this course has opened my eyes and given me a different perspective. Knowing the background and stereotypes we have. I can take all I have learned in the course in and out of the classroom. Suzannah had great books that I never heard of. We want to get disability books for the classroom as well as diversity books.

Alex Lauric shared her perspective.

Clare Flaherty: at our last PTO McGlynn meeting, we thought about ways we can support students at different levels next year. Part of my frustrations have been the fly by the seat of our pants operation model. Next year might be difficult but maybe we can plan a little bit more to address the backsliding of behavioral health issues. I am concerned about reintegration of students with disabilities. I see in the remote classrooms, that kids' tolerance of other kids is going down. I hope to encourage the district to start talking about it now. I would like to hear that mental health and supportive health is being addressed for next year. One of the ways I was thinking about this was wearing PTO hat about actionable things we can do. After Amanda Gorman spoke at McGlynn, I started thinking about art and music therapy for students' emotional needs. I thought it would be a good approach for a community based activity.

Melanie: I know that music therapy was offered at the Brooks and was well received.

Suzannah Campbell: I will make those materials to the committee. The district did purchase all of the books on the list so they are available. One participant is a school librarian and she created a document of books with disabilities representation across grade levels.

Carla Andre: I don't want to lose sight of the inclusion aspect. I don't want to put students on a panel and ask them about their disabilities.

Suzanne Galusi: Following Clare Flaherty, on Monday's school committee meeting we

announced listening sessions in March to plan for next year. We have been planning in collaboration with Stacey Schulman on this. How are we going to use the summer to help these kids transition.

Clare Flaherty: I just encourage you to over communicate this to parents that this Social emotional piece is so important. We know you know it but need to hear it louder.

Stacey Schulman: I know that social and emotional well being is on our minds. We know we need to listen to all voices on this in preparing for next year. Every person's experience is very different. We know school in the beginning of the year will look very different next year. We are preparing our staff with PD. Ten of our staff became certified anxiety specialists. We will be certifying trauma specialists as well. Students have shown resilience and openness in this and we need to keep listening and providing support the best way we can. I had a conversation with Michael Tennant with an empathy expert. His goal is honest conversations, active listening and empathy. I hope to foster this in our schools. I love your suggestion for art therapy, It is expensive and hard to fit into the schools. I would like to have an after school club for art therapy and will look for grant opportunities going forward to support it.

Alex Lauric: I think there should be a district wide prioritization about Social Emotional health but am concerned about the rush to gain the academics that they are behind on.

Dr. Cushing: We are also in initial stages of planning summer work and hope to build in more outside activities and nature.

Paul Ruseau: The issue of homework has received various levels of attention. How does the admin feel about making shifts to equitable grading? Homework? We have blown the whole thing up and should we put it together exactly how it was before? I am wondering if the admin is talking about these shifts?

Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent: we definitely need to think about putting it back together and we need to look at data to make decisions. We need to differentiate instruction using UDL. There is no one size fits all method for every student in a classroom. As adults, we are still adjusting to life right now. As we look at what worked well, what didn't work well. We will listen at the sessions next month and also get additional guidance from the state. There may be official switches for all districts this year. We are aware things will look different but need more information and more data to plan for next school year.

Melanie McLaughlin: I think it would be great to have student listening sessions. Peter

Cushing: We have them scheduled from 3:30 to 4:30 on all the days of the sessions.

Melanie McLaughlin: In regards to the art therapy piece, I can do some research into Roman Music Therapy and some grants towards the Social Emotional piece.

Stacey Schulman: Lesley University has a great art therapy program. We have had interns work with us as well. The challenge is the scheduling so that students can access it in a meaningful way. Ideally it would be an hour or longer. Could put it in the advisory or WIN blocks. When Dr. Perella was here, meditation experts came in. There are a lot of options that we could use to serve as many students as possible.

Melanie McLaughlin: I would love to tap into the expertise that we have in the community.

Sarah: I would like to see more in the future. I would like to see the behavioral therapy change. Not the same as real situations. Parent of a child in 7th grade.

Melanie McLaughlin: What I am hearing is that the support is more difficult during the pandemic.

Stacey: We have four BCBAs that work in the district as well as a behavioral specialist. They do offer hands-on services.

Sarah: Consultants who are once in a while aren't able to provide consistency.

Melanie McLaughlin: what are the steps when parents need more support?

Joan Bowen : if you are feeling that your child needs more services, you have a right to ask for a team meeting to request additional services. As children get older, we want them to generalize the skills and move to the consult model.

Sarah: I understand this position but the services need to be more stable positions. This is not only about my son.

Tonya Sullivan: I encourage you to attend the listening sessions and express your concerns.

Melanie McLaughlin; Thank you Sarah for attending the meeting and expressing your opinions. I agree this is a broader problem. Once behavior becomes problematic, everyone suffers.

Tonya: What I am getting from Sarah, is in light of all the behavioral things we will encounter when we go back, we may want to address the needs of older children differently.

Next meeting is March 18 from 5 to 6:30. BH first, SPED second.

Motion to adjourn: Mea Mustone, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau
6:24